

Baleen whales

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Cetacea
SUBORDER	Mysticeti
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	14

The most striking feature of baleen whales is their size, which ranges from up to 21 ft (6.5 m) in the pygmy right whale to 110 ft (33 m) in the blue whale. Also characteristic are the baleen plates, which filter prey from the water. The group consists of the gray whale, the rorquals (which include the humpback whale and the blue whale), and right whales. Although commonly found in Antarctic and Arctic regions, they are distributed throughout all the world's oceans, usually in deep water.

Anatomy

All whales in this group have 2 rows of baleen plates (see p.244) that are anchored to either side of the upper jaw. To support these structures, the jaws are elongated. This means that the head, which has 2 blowholes, is large in relation to the body. In right whales, the head comprises up to half the body length, and the jaws are deep (to accommodate long baleen plates). The body is relatively short and stout. Rorquals, on the other hand, have a long, slender body, and shorter baleens.

Feeding

While the gray whale feeds on small crustaceans called amphipods (which are found on the sea bottom), right whales and rorquals eat planktonic crustaceans, which live near the surface. Right whales feed by swimming slowly through dense schools of prey with their mouths open, skimming the plankton out of the water. Rorquals are more active hunters

and usually surround their prey. As they feed, the grooves in the throat are relaxed, and the lower jaw becomes a vast sac into which water is gulped. When the water is expelled, the prey remains on the baleen plates. The larger species of rorquals have finer bristles on their baleen plates, which trap crustaceans such as krill and sometimes small fish. Smaller species have coarser bristles to catch larger crustaceans and small fish. The gray whale feeds by stirring up sediments with its relatively short, firm snout, then gulping down its prey, often together with sand, silt, and pebbles.

Migration

Most baleen whale species are migratory. Rorquals, which are known for traveling long distances, feed in the Arctic and Antarctic (where krill is abundant) during the summer. In autumn and winter, they migrate to tropical waters. Here,

although they feed little, they give birth and mate again immediately. In spring, they then slowly move back toward higher latitudes, with their suckling calves. Although humpback whales usually migrate along coastlines, other rorquals prefer deeper water. The gray whale holds the record for the longest migration—13,988 miles (22,511 km).

Communication

Baleen whales communicate using a variety of sounds, from squeals to rumbles. The most famous whale sounds are the “songs” of male humpbacks. These are produced during winter breeding and consist of a repeated series of high and low notes that are gradually varied as the season progresses. The songs are vital for communication in the vast oceans. Other species employ different sounds; the fin whale, for example, produces a call that is below the range of human hearing and travels huge distances through the ocean.

UNUSUAL FEEDING TECHNIQUE

Baleen whales feed by taking large quantities of small prey. This humpback whale, having circled upward through a school of small fish, is gulping a large mouthful of water and fish. As the mouth closes, the water presses against the rigid upper jaws and flows out over the baleen plates, leaving the fish behind.

